

TRUMP FIRES NOEM AS CHIEF OF D.H.S. AFTER ROCKY TERM

Criticism Over Handling Ad Contracts — Senator Is Named as Replacement

This article is by **Michael C. Bender, Michael Gold, Hamed Aleaziz and Maggie Haberman.**

WASHINGTON — President Trump fired Kristi Noem as homeland security secretary on Thursday and announced plans to replace her with Senator Markwayne Mullin of Oklahoma, concluding a long-building frustration with Ms. Noem that had come to a head this week with her grilling by Republicans at congressional hearings.

Mr. Trump announced the change on social media, along with a new, and previously nonexistent, role for Ms. Noem inside the administration: special envoy for the Shield of the Americas, which he said would be a new security initiative for the Western Hemisphere.

Mr. Trump is close with Mr. Mullin, a Republican, and speaks

with him regularly. Mr. Mullin said that Ms. Noem had “done the best that she could do under the circumstances,” but that he hoped to learn from her tenure and “build off things that didn’t quite go as planned.” Mr. Trump said Ms. Noem would remain in her current role until March 31. She thanked him in her own social media post.

The immediate catalyst for Ms. Noem’s firing appeared to be her answers during two congressional hearings this week, particularly her under-threat-of-perjury statements that Mr. Trump had approved of tens of millions of dollars of government ads in which she was prominently featured. Mr. Trump denied that to Reuters on Thursday, saying, “I never knew anything about it.”

Mr. Trump was shown clips of her answers before a Senate panel and was angry that she blamed him for the contentious spots, according to a person with knowledge of what happened who was not authorized to discuss the matter publicly. The ads were part of a \$200 million-plus government-funded campaign that included a subcontractor run by the husband of Ms. Noem’s now-former spokeswoman, Tricia McLaughlin.

The uproar over the ads came as recent Wall Street Journal articles detailed Ms. Noem’s spending decisions — on private jets, including one with a bedroom and only 18 seats that she said would

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Kristi Noem is the first cabinet member to be ousted in the president’s second term.

Wielding Emergency Orders, Justices Leapfrog State Courts

By ANN E. MARIMOW

WASHINGTON — When the Supreme Court issued an emergency order this week that protected the congressional district of a New York Republican, it intervened in a voting rights dispute, pre-empting the state’s highest court before it had a chance to act.

Since President Trump returned to the White House, the Supreme Court’s conservative majority has shown a willingness to short-circuit lower-court proceedings with a slew of emergency rulings in federal cases. But this was a rare instance in which the justices leapfrogged the state courts, too — a sign, legal experts said, that despite intense scrutiny of how the Supreme Court has been using its emergency docket, the conservative justices appear to be expanding its use rather than constraining it.

Unlike the court’s traditional

“merits” cases, which arrive after months or years of lower-court consideration, emergency requests are fast-tracked with limited briefing and almost always without oral argument. The emergency docket has exploded in recent years, particularly in the second Trump administration, with the filings accounting for a significant part of the justices’ workload. While the quick-turn orders are technically place holders, they can effectively settle significant issues while litigation plays out in the lower courts.

The order in the New York case was unsigned and included no reasoning, as is typical. The three liberal justices joined in a 13-page dissent to assert that the majority had interfered with New York court proceedings in an inappropriate and unorthodox

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Fight Over Climate Law Looms As New York Energy Costs Soar

By HILARY HOWARD

Jake Korolev has written letters to Con Edison, asked the utility to check his meter and filed a complaint with regulators. He is vigilant about turning off his lights and even his breaker when he leaves town. But his power bills are still north of \$400 a month.

“Between rent and energy, I can’t save money,” said Mr. Korolev, 28, who works in the live music industry and lives in Bushwick, Brooklyn. “It weighs on me every month.”

As demand for power has soared in the United States, sky-high electricity bills have followed, contributing to an affordability crisis across the country. Gov. Mikie Sherrill of New Jersey declared a state of emergency on utility costs on her first day in office, and President Trump broached the topic with Mayor

Zohran Mamdani during their first meeting at the White House.

These concerns have prompted Gov. Kathy Hochul of New York to consider drastic changes to the state’s 2019 climate law, the implementation of which, her agencies say, could lead to even higher energy bills.

In New York, among the 10 most expensive states in terms of electricity costs, the battle over utility rates is pitting climate activists and like-minded legislators, who believe it’s crucial to aggressively ramp up solar, offshore wind and other green energy projects, against supporters of Ms. Hochul’s “all of the above” approach, which emphasizes a balanced mix of energy sources, including nuclear.

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After Evacuation Order Unsettles Beirut, Israel Begins Bomb Campaign Near City



LEBANON A highway in the Dahiya, on Beirut’s outskirts, after Israel issued an evacuation order.



TEHRAN Azadi Stadium, which hosted Frank Sinatra and big soccer matches, was hit by an attack.



ISRAEL Family members looked over the damage to their home Thursday after a missile barrage.

‘AVALANCHE!’

An Explosion of Snow, Ice and Debris, Then Came Calls for Help

This article is by **Dave Philipps, Bora Erden, Marco Hernandez and Amy Graff.**

TRUCKEE, Calif. — The blizzard blew so fierce that the skier at the head of the line kept disappearing into a whiteout. The winds were gusting over 50 miles per hour. Almost four feet of fresh powder had piled up and more was falling every minute.

At the back of the line was Anton Auzans, trudging behind 12 other backcountry skiers climbing through a clearing high in California’s Sierra Nevada. He had his hood pulled low against the pelting wind.

Then came a single word yelled by a ski guide somewhere ahead: “Avalanche!”

Mr. Auzans looked up in time to see a wall of white dotted with strange blurs of color. In the moment before it reached him, he realized that the colors were the tumbling skis and clothing of the other skiers.

He jumped behind a dead tree for protection, but the snow was surging down the mountain like a raging river. It poured around the trunk, dragged him away and swallowed him in darkness.

Hundreds of thousands of pounds of snow rushed into the clearing, slowing as it spilled over flatter ground, and settled into a dense pile and a terrible silence. The slide had buried everyone in the group. Almost.

Two men from the group had fallen behind.

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Jim Hamilton



Anton Auzans

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INTERNATIONAL A4-10
Nepal Votes for a New Guard
Six months after a Gen Z revolution led to the overthrow of the government, a millennial rapper turned mayor could become prime minister. PAGE A6

NATIONAL A11-20
Measles in a Skeptical County
In South Carolina, a community that is generally distrustful of vaccines has now become ground zero for the largest measles outbreak since 2000. PAGE A11

OBITUARIES A21
He Lifted Notre Dame to Glory
Lou Holtz, who coached six major colleges to bowl games, captured a national title in the 1988 season with an undefeated Irish team. He was 89.

WEEKEND ARTS C1-12
A Looser Whitney Biennial
This year’s presentation has no overarching theme but touches on climate disaster, border policing and other moral anxieties of the moment. PAGE C1